DHUM101: Structured Report Assessment

Weight: 30% of your final mark

Due: 4.30pm, Monday 10 August, via Aoroa

Your goal with this assessment is to analyse an argument about some aspect of digital technology and its social, cultural, or ethical effects; i.e. someone claiming something about technology is good or bad. This is not a free-form essay. Answer each question below using the word count for each item as a guide. This will force you to be selective and concise in what you say: an important skill in itself.

To write a strong assessment, you will of course need to read (or watch) the item you're analysing. Likely, you will read it several times. You will also want to go beyond that one item, doing research where possible to understand the context of the argument. Who is writing? At the end, add references to any items that you've used beyond the target essay. Cite those items in your response where needed. Any standard referencing format (APA, Vancouver, Chicago, MLA, etc.) is accepted.

AI Use: The purpose of this task is for you to build your reflective skills in assessing claims and arguments. This is not just a task for a class. You will encounter people wanting you to believe things every day, and so it helps to become more proficient at it. Asking a Large Language Model to analyse the article itself defeats the goal. Therefore, please do not use AI for generating ideas or answering the specific questions. After you have done your own analysis, it is fine to use AI to check spelling, grammar, etc. We will not be heavily weighting spelling and grammar in marking.

To complete the assessment, add your answers to this document and submit through Aoroa. Your answers (excluding references) should be 1500 words in total. If you edit this document by adding your answers and do not delete the instructions and questions, the total document word count (excluding references) should come to 2200 words.[1] You can go 10% over without penalty.

Choose ONE of the items below to analyse:

1. Sam Altman, The Gentle Singularity. https://blog.samaltman.com/the-gentle-singularity
2. Cory Doctorow, Enshittification interview on The Daily Show. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=d2e-c9SF5nE
   (Please note that this choice will include humorous swearing including expletives.)
3. David Kruerger, No, AI is not Inevitable. We should stop it while we can. https://www.usatoday.com/story/opinion/2026/01/24/ai-chip-manufacturing-data-centers-humanity/88215945007/
4. Casey Fielder, AI has social consequences, but who pays the price? https://theconversation.com/ai-has-social-consequences-but-who-pays-the-price-tech-companies-problem-with-ethical-debt-203375

[1] *Microsoft Word shows the word count in the status bar at the bottom of the window. If no text is highlighted, you see the total word count for the document. If you highlight a region, e.g. everything except the references, you see, e.g., "2185 of 2312 words", where the first number is the word count for the highlighted region.*

Your Report

You may insert new lines.

Section 1. Foundations

Which item are you analysing?

Who is the author? Do they have existing connections to the topic? What are those connections? [100 words]

Section 2. Claims and evidence.

What does the article or interview want you to believe? What are its key claims? [100 words]

What is the evidence for the main claim(s)? Do they provide ways to check this evidence? Is the presentation of evidence appropriate for the type of article or presentation? [200 words]

Does the evidence in fact support the claim(s)? Many items may be considered here including but not limited to: A formal or informal logic error, bias, trustworthiness of the source, and ambiguity. [300 words]

What is missing from the argument? What facts are being left unsaid? Is this part of an existing debate? What are the other positions? [200 words]

Section 3. Consequences and Benefits

Why do they want you to care? How do they try to get you to care? Are there appeals to emotion? To morality? To consequences? [100 words]

What do they want you to do? (Recall that inaction is an action.) [100 words]

What are the effects of the actions? Who do they directly affect? Who do they directly benefit? What about indirect effects? [200 words]

Section 4. Conclusions

After this analysis, are you convinced by the argument? Why or why not? Summarise your own conclusions. [200 words]

References